

****Holiday Season Safety Tips****

The holiday season brings much joy, gatherings, and good wishes. To ensure your safety and maintain a good mood during this time, we have prepared a list of common traps and online scams, along with advice on how to protect yourself from them. Safeguard your personal data and that of others, and enjoy a carefree holiday season!

1. **Do all greetings contain only good wishes?**

Christmas and New Year's are times when we send and receive numerous greetings from our loved ones as well as various senders. However, some messages may contain viruses, malware, and are most often used for phishing. Phishing refers to online scams in the form of fake emails that appear to be sent by legitimate organizations (for example, a bank or an online shopping site) and prompt the recipient to share personal, financial, or security information. In this way, scammers gain access to usernames, passwords, or credit card information. Such emails often ask you to download an attached document or click on a link. Therefore, it is recommended to exercise caution before opening attachments or clicking on links found in messages, especially if the message comes from an unknown sender and if the text is full of spelling errors. If the sender seems suspicious, do not open the email. Also, pay attention to the file extensions in the attachment – do not open attachments with unusual extensions such as .jar, .ace. If you receive a suspicious link in an email, hover over the URL address but do not click – you should see the actual URL to which you will be redirected. If it looks suspicious or ends with .exe, .js, or .zip, do not open the link!

2. **A relaxed group photo or a problem?**

The Christmas season is a time for parties, gatherings, and travel. Are you posting your and others' photos/videos on social media without thinking and questioning? Do you have your privacy settings set so that anyone can see everything you post? Consider whether this is wise – content that you wouldn't want your parents, boss, or work colleague to see should not be posted online. If you are posting photos or videos featuring other people, it is necessary to ask for their consent for such a post. Pay special attention to photos that include children and minors – protect them! Avoid posting pictures of children and minors or limit the visibility settings of the post to just your friends.

3. **Is every discount really a good discount?**

The holiday spirit and shopping for Christmas gifts can be spoiled by fake online shops aimed at stealing personal data and financial gain. Big discounts can indeed be tempting, and everyone aims to save money, but to ensure that you are buying from a verified online store, follow these tips:

- Beware of “too good to be true offers” on unverified online shops.
- Check if the merchant's website lists the name and registered office, phone number, and email address.
- Use verified online stores. You can check the credibility of the domain at the following link:
<https://www.scamadviser.com/>
- Research reviews before making a purchase.
- Do not send copies of your ID and bank cards.
- If you are paying by card, only use secure payment service providers when making a purchase.
- Only pay when you are connected to a secure connection – avoid free or open WiFi.
- Pay only on a secure device – regularly update your operating system and security software.

4. **Winner of a prize or a loser?**

During the holiday season, organizations on social media take the opportunity to increase their follower count through giveaways. The rules are usually simple: leave a comment under the post and/or tag a friend, and with a little luck, the prize is yours. However, be cautious and:

- Check the profile of the giveaway organizer. Is the official name of the organizer spelled correctly, is the profile newly opened, and is the first and only post a giveaway? If you notice a mistake in the name or the profile has no other posts, the giveaway is likely fake; do not leave your personal information!
- After the official organizer posts a giveaway, fake profiles often appear that imitate the official profile (usually adding just a symbol, e.g., a dot or dash to the official name) and message individuals who commented under the original post claiming they are winners and asking for personal data delivery.

Before providing personal data, verify that it is the official profile where you left your comment.

- Have you received a message that you have won a prize, but the organizer asks you to fill in your credit card details so they can send you the prize?

If you are a winner, the organizer does not need your credit card information; your delivery details (name, surname, address, and possibly contact) are sufficient. Do not enter your card details!

Consider whether the prize sounds too good to be true, for example, a car dealership is giving away personal cars, and all you have to do is leave a comment. Such games are often scams; avoid them!

5. Happy anticipation of a package at your home address or uncertainty on your checking account?

Has the delivery service informed you that you have received a package and that to receive it at your home address, they sent you a payment link? During the holiday season and the increased number of online purchases, there has also been an increase in fraudulent activity where scammers send fake notifications about received packages via email and request payment to deliver your shipment. You will notice a fake notification by the text, which often contains spelling mistakes and an email address that does not match the official email address of the delivery service, therefore:

Check the sender's email address

Do not open suspicious links that request payment

Do not enter or send personal information and card number

Permanently delete the email

6. Install smartly

Do you want to have a creative and personalized greeting card to send to friends and family? Today, there are numerous free applications available for creating Christmas cards, and to ensure that you do not install a virus or malware with the application, follow these tips:

Read the app description (if it contains errors, it is necessary to be suspicious)

Before installing the app, read what data is collected, how long it is stored, and how it will be used

Download apps only from official app store websites

Warn children not to download apps on their own

Bonus tip: If you frequently use credit cards for online shopping, it is advisable to set up notifications for every transaction you make in real-time, so you can detect potential unauthorized use of your card and respond promptly by contacting your bank.